RUNBOOK

Your agent isn't dumb. It just has no memory.

Anthropic just broke down why most agent demos fall apart after session one.

WHY THIS MATTERS NOW

Anthropic mapped the real memory problem

Published hours ago, lands right in the middle of the agent reliability debate.

- Most agents look smart in a demo, then forget context fast
- The gap isn't the model, it's the memory architecture around it
- This gives builders an actual framework instead of guesswork

THE MECHANISM

Working memory has four moving parts

Each one fails in a different way if you skip it.

- Context window: what the model can see right now
- Retrieval: pulling the right past info back in
- Summarization: compressing history so it still fits
- State: tracking facts that persist across turns

WHERE DEMOS BREAK

Context windows are not memory

This is the mistake almost every early agent build makes.

- A full context window just means more tokens, not more memory
- Once the session ends, that context is gone
- Without retrieval or state, the agent starts from zero next time

THE FIX, PART 1

Retrieval decides what the agent remembers

This is where RAG and knowledge systems actually earn their keep.

- Store past interactions somewhere outside the model
- Pull back only what's relevant to the current task
- Bad retrieval means the agent recalls the wrong thing confidently

THE FIX, PART 2

Summarization keeps long tasks usable

Long-running agents need compression, not just storage.

- Raw history grows too large to keep feeding the model
- Summaries preserve the decisions without the noise
- Done badly, you lose the exact detail that mattered

THE FIX, PART 3

State is the part people skip

This is what makes an agent feel consistent across sessions.

- State tracks facts like user preferences or task progress
- It lives outside the conversation, in a database or object
- Without it, every session restarts the relationship from scratch

PRACTICAL TAKEAWAY

Design memory before you design the agent

Ask these four questions before writing a single prompt.

- What does it need to recall tomorrow, not just this turn?
- Where does retrieval pull from, and how is it indexed?
- What gets summarized, and what detail can't be lost?
- What state actually needs to persist between sessions?

CTA

What's breaking in your agent builds right now?

If memory is the part you keep bolting on after the fact, happy to compare notes on architecture.